

Executive Board Decision Document

EXECUTIVE BOARD:

Name 1, Corporate Services & Chief Financial Officer

TITLE:

2017 Telehealth Expansion on Vancouver Island and Southern Gulf Islands

ISSUE: FOR DECISION

- An expansion of the Telehealth network is required to address the growing demand for health services by rural communities, and address the uneven distribution of health coverage on Vancouver Island.
- The issue aligns with critical goals within Island Health's 2015 to 2020 Strategic Health Service Plan and in conjunction with the Office of Continuing Professional Development (CPD) Infrastructure Service Plan.
- A decision must be approved before March 20th 2017 as to allow sufficient time for budget changes in accordance with the March 31st 2017 deadline for 2018 fiscal year planning.

RECOMMENDATION:

Approve the \$2.2 million allocation request for CPD's Telehealth Expansion Program. The funding will be allocated to the 2017-18 fiscal year budget on April 15th 2017. The expansion would consist of:

1. Constructing and equipping 2 new dual use Telehealth clinics for consultations and conferences in the Central Island district, and 1 new consult and treatment clinic in the North Island district.
2. Hiring 6 new technical support staff members to facilitate training and maintenance.

BACKGROUND:

As of January 2017, Telehealth services are enabled in 23 communities and 59 locations on Vancouver Island. Approximately 3,700 telehealth visits were carried out, 840 of which corresponded to Mental Health and Substance Use services and 630 corresponded to health learning modules and conferences.¹

- In 2016, mental health issues continued to constitute the highest inpatient reason in the northern island communities with an average commute time of 3 hours to the nearest mental health clinic.
- CPD has identified manpower and space shortages, lack of locum coverage, an unwillingness of health educators to travel to rural communities, physician isolation, and geographic difficulty travelling to urban centers as issues hindering patient care in northern island communities.²
- A key priority of CPD's Infrastructure Service Plan is to expand Telehealth to support high needs populations in remote service areas.

¹ Island Health 2017 Telehealth Report, p.2.

² CPD Infrastructure Service Report 2016, p. 4.

- Approximately 38% of all Island Health staff in the northern and central districts have not received the most up to date clinical and safety protocol training due to the issues and barriers to care outlined by the CPD.³

Strategic Drivers

CPD recommendations are focused on targeting the following Island Health Strategic Drivers:

- Uneven distribution of health between rural and non-rural communities.
- Rising health challenges of chronic diseases.
- Reduction of geographic barriers.

OPTIONS:

Option 1: No Telehealth Expansion or Upgrades

- No new equipment, or network upgrades are obtained. Island Health maintains the current 59 Telehealth locations on Vancouver Island.
- This option is **not recommended**, as it does not address Island Health's Strategic Drivers or CPD's Telehealth Expansion Plan.

Advantages:

- No need for any changes to the 2017/2018 Infrastructure Service Plan budget.
- No facility disruptions associated with renovations and upgrades.

Disadvantages:

- Lack of engagement with rural community health services as geographic barriers to travel remain.
- Patients in central island communities without access to psychiatry will continue to have to commute a minimum of 2 hours to the nearest mental health clinic.
- Patients in northern island communities without access to psychiatry will continue to have to commute a minimum of 3 hours to the nearest mental health clinic.
- The number of mental health related emergency room visits will continue to increase with patients unable to access important mental health services such as psychiatry.

Option 2: Upgrade Existing Telehealth Infrastructure

- Approximately \$240,000 is allocated to the Infrastructure Service Plan for the upgrade of Telehealth equipment, purchasing of new mobile videoconferencing carts, and new clinical peripherals.
- Island Health maintains the current 59 Telehealth locations on Vancouver Island.
- This option is **not recommended**, as it does not address Island Health's Strategic Drivers or CPD's plan of Telehealth expansion as part of the Infrastructure Service plan.

Advantages:

- Approximately \$2 million saved and can be re-allocated.
- New mobile videoconference carts allow for more flexibility when booking visits, leading to a marginal increase in service capacity.

³ CPD Infrastructure Service Report 2016, p. 8.

Disadvantages:

- The marginal increase in service capacity is unlikely to address the growing demand for Mental health and long-term care services in central and northern communities.
- Lack of engagement with rural community health services as geographic barriers to travel remain.

Option 3: Expand Central Island Telehealth Network

- Approve the \$2.2 million allocation to CPD for Telehealth network and infrastructure expansion.
- Funding will cover construction and equipping of one new Telehealth clinic in Sayward, as well as new Telehealth dual use consult and conference rooms within the new upcoming Courtney and Campbell River hospitals.
- Funding will also be used to hire 6 new technical support staff to assist with training and support.
- This option is **recommended** as it is consistent with Island Health's Strategic Drivers and CPD's plan of Telehealth expansion as part of the Infrastructure Service plan.

Advantages:

- Increases Telehealth service coverage in the North Island district;
- Increases Telehealth service capacity in the Central Island district.
- The additional Telehealth conference space is expected to close the delay on a total of 12 training modules for Oncology, Cardiology, and Mental Health, and furthermore, targets the Island Health Strategic Driver regarding emphasis on chronic disease care.

Disadvantages:

- Approval will require the full \$2.2 million budget allocation.
- Approximately 4 rooms in the West hospital wings in both the Courtney and Campbell River hospitals will remain out of use for 3 additional months due to additional construction.

Fiscal Management Considerations:

- No additional funding request from the Ministry of Health is required.
- The table below examines the capital and operating costs associated with CPD's Telehealth Expansion Plan;
- It is important to note the approximate \$304,000 in added operating costs going forward in the future associated with this infrastructure expansion.

Table 1: Summary of Expected Capital Costs and Increase in Operating Costs for Full Telehealth Expansion.

One-Time Capital Costs	Three new full video conferencing systems and peripherals	Clinic construction	Soundproofing	Network setup
	\$200,000	\$1,200,000	\$60,000	\$60,000
On-going Operating Costs	Six new technical support staff	Added Network		
	\$300,000/year	\$3600/year		

Implications of Recommended Option:

- Adding the three new Telehealth sites would cut wait times for psychiatry, addictions, and oncology visits by an estimated average of eight weeks.
- The new central island consult/conference Telehealth rooms combined will be able to facilitate an estimated 200 new video seminars for education modules based on current usage patterns.

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- Once completed, the consult/conference rooms will be able to address the four-month delay in training modules for new onboarding clinical programs by alleviating the lack of consult space for meetings delivered by video conferencing.

Executive Consultation:

The Executive Team has been briefed on the proposed CPD Telehealth Expansion Plan. Bi-monthly meetings are ongoing with the IMIT Board of Directors to discuss network expansion protocols and privacy protection associated with adding the extra Telehealth Network. As of March, 15th 2017, the IMIT Board approved the current CPD network expansion procedures and guidelines.

RECOMMENDED DECISION:

It is recommended that the Executive Board approve CPD's Telehealth Expansion Plan and adhere to the CPD Infrastructure Service Plan and the key drivers of the Island Health 2015 to 2020 Strategic Health Plan. The proposed network and infrastructure upgrades will help bridge the gap between rural and non-rural care, thus reducing geographic barriers and uneven distribution of health care.

SIGNATURE:

Approved by:

Name
Corporate Services & Chief Financial Officer

DATE: March 12, 2017

KEY CONTACT:

Contact 1, SSC, Project Manager, (123) 456-7890

Contact 2, Telehealth Systems Manager, (123) 456-7890